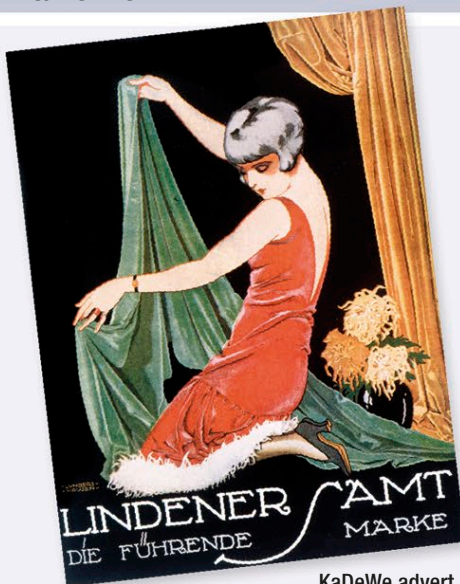


1917–1935

BERLINER CHIC

In 1929 the writer and translator Franz Hessel published observations made during walks in Berlin. He remarked that the sight of young women in “well-fitted clothes and little hats oozing a lock of hair” should be enough to convince anyone that “Berlin is well on the way to becoming an elegant city”. The many *Konfektion* (ready-to-wear) manufacturers based in Berlin had long transformed the dictates of Paris into clothes displaying the famous Berliner chic. While the Golden Twenties lasted – from around 1923 to 1929 – Berlin became a magnet for artists, writers, and performers such as Josephine Baker who appeared with *La Revue Nègre* in 1925. Audiences flocked to the theatres, watched productions of the Berlin-based UFA – Germany’s largest film company – in thousand-seater cinemas, and gaped at synchronized kicklines. Entertainment of a different kind could be found in Berlin’s many gay and lesbian clubs, including the Eldorado where transvestites mingled with members of Berlin’s high society.

KaDeWe



KaDeWe advert

Kaufhaus des Westens (Department Store of the West), or KaDeWe, was and still is one of Berlin’s leading retail establishments. Opened in 1907, its 120 departments housed smaller shops. The owner hoped to satisfy the desires of Berlin’s high society. This poster advertises *Lindener Samt* (velvet from Linden) – a high-quality cotton velvet.

Ostrich-feather sash

Bar shoes of metallic leather



Asymmetric hem

Ostrich feathers This 1925 evening gown created by the Berlin fashion house Jacob Hobe is modelled by a lookalike of the surrealist muse Lee Miller. Ostrich feathers dyed in a matching colour floated around the wearer while dancing.

Dark stage make-up

Short skirt made of feathers or fringes

1917

Dance Valeska Gert first appeared on the stage during World War I. In her grotesque dance performances she parodied themes such as ballet, boxing, and prostitution. Her costume foreshadows the silhouette of the *robe de style* of the 1920s.

Thick tights

Dance shoes



Wide-brimmed hat

Matching scarf

Dark silk stockings

1927

Theatrical cane

Modernism Berlin-style elegance found a home in other European capitals. In 1927 Marlene Dietrich appeared on the stage in Vienna and also found time to appear in the silent film *Electric Café*. Here, she models a modernist day ensemble.

